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LEADER IN ADAPTIVE PREPARATION FOR CAT

AIRCAT-2511 Dissection

AIRCAT-2511 would have been a not-so-pleasant experience for most of you if you saw it as an end. This time around the challenge would have been more from a difficulty level point of view. However, if you see something like this as a means to an end, as something that gives you invaluable exposure to test that not only tested your ability but also your temperament, as something that is just a learning ground for the real CAT, then this test might just have been a defining point of your CAT Prep.

Since not much is known about the composition of the exam except that it would have 3 sections of equal duration, and almost equal number of marks, we consciously try and ensure that you experience variety in the AIRCATs so that you find it easier to adapt to whatever surprises CAT comes up with finally. And at the cost of sounding repetitive, a calm head, unflinching concentration for the duration of the test and devoting some time for planning your approach initially and then reviewing/adapting intermittently are most crucial to your chances of success in an exam such as the CAT.

Once again, it would not be surprising if most of you feel that your performance level was significantly lower than ideal. Not only are you dealing with changes in the format and platform from life-long offline tests to online tests (which anyhow is an identical challenge for all aspirants) but also because this test was overall on the tougher side. Oh, but that you already know 😊

With not too many easy questions for you to really get going in any of the sections, scoring would not have been easy, and scoring high would have proved unexpectedly tough. No section was easy enough to completely dominate. Therefore, the overall level of the AIRCAT was Difficult. Realizing that, you should have known that far fewer correct attempts could help you do very well.

Let us now look at a detailed sectional analysis in terms of (relative) difficulty level:

	Easy	Intermediate	Difficult	Difficulty Level	Cut off Questions (Marks)
Section I (VRC)	5	11	8	Difficult	12 (23)
Section II (DILR)	1	9	12	Difficult	8 (15)
Section III (QA)	3	11	8	Difficult	10 (18)
Overall	9	31	28	Very Difficult	29 (58)

SECTION I: VRC

The English part began mercilessly with RC dominating the same, as has been the norm over the past few years in CAT. The relatively abstract passage and poem that followed would not have made it

any easier though their respective lengths made them far more doable than would have been possible otherwise. Passages with questions 11-14 and 15-19 were probably the most doable given the relative ease of questions. 15-19 especially was a relatively simple passage (that however required careful comprehension) with a big takeaway of 5 questions. The relatively shorter length of passages from 11-14, 15-19 made it relatively easy to browse and decide whether to attempt.

Almost all Para-Jumbles questions (20-22) were attemptable, but the lack of options made them tedious with a poor risk-reward ratio. The OOC questions at the end of the section would have been challenging for most.

Overall, an uncharacteristically tough VRC would have meant that even a score as low as 23 would have got you past the cut-off and placed you in the Top 10%ile in this section.

SECTION II: DILR

The only relatively doable (in assessing, certainty of solving and then in actually solving) sets seemed to be 34-38 (rankings of car models) and 39-42 (Hockey World Cups). While 25-28 was also a doable set, the pressure builds quickly in a tough section and every second that ticks away takes away your ability to stay calm and assess a question and its difficulty correctly and confidently. Hence, the overall difficulty level of the section would have not only ensured below-par question selection but also induced more errors. With only a handful of easy questions and they too spread across different sets, this was a tough test of your DILR skills as well as management. Even a score of 15, which needed only 2 sets to be solved partially, would have got you a place in the Top-7-8 %ile and helped you sail past the cut-off in this section.

SECTION III: QA

The QA part had questions spread nearly uniformly across Arithmetic, Geometry/Mensuration and Algebra. The fact that there were hardly any easy questions among the first 7-8 questions in SECTION-III would have made for a challenging start for most of you. It is remarkable how the perceived ease or difficulty of first few questions in a section can affect your mental make-up and can impact your confidence and approach. Instead of looking out for easier questions, you tend to start believing that it is either too tough a test or it is not your day.

In an exam where success is based on relative performance, a tough or an easy paper does not matter – all that matters is how well you adapt to its level. The questions from Arithmetic were spread across Number systems, Percentages, Interest Time & work and Time & speed. The questions from Number Systems, in particular, were easy if you had the basics in place. The questions that should not have been missed ideally included 51, 65 and 68. Overall, both the level of the questions and the placement of the section at the end, which typically means most of you are past your best concentration levels, meant that the section was tough. A score of around 18 would have placed you in the Top 7-8% ile in this section.

Summary:
As mentioned earlier, strategy, order of attempting Sets/Questions within a section, time-distribution on different question types and question selection play a vital role in your chances of success. While question selection and time-distribution are inter-related, strategy would also include decision like which type of questions to begin with. Especially in a test such as this one, where there are not too many easy pickings, and questions at the beginning of each Section are tougher, staying calm, and picking out questions according to your strength would have been a good strategy. Starting (where you try and build momentum and confidence) and ending (when time pressure is the highest) with your strengths is usually advisable.

Tentative sectional and overall benchmarks are given below

	98%ile	95%ile	90%ile	85%ile
Section I (VRC)	31	25	22	18
Section II (DILR)	21	17	15	13
Section III (QA)	24	20	17	15
Overall	62	52	44	40

-AIRCAT Spinner Team (AST)